did my homework: I used to pop into Alan Smith's house and his mum, Pat, would help me with some of it. She was really good at Maths, I remember, and Alan was too. He's in insurance now, working for Rothschild, and I run into him now and again: he's married and has moved away but he works from an office in his mum and dad's loft. The important thing was that I never missed a day's school, unless I was ill, at either Chase Lane Primary or at Chingford High.

If it hadn't been soccer, I don't know what I would have ended up doing when I grew up. I liked Music lessons and, at primary school, they thought I had a decent voice. I sang a solo in the school choir just before I left there. One subject I really enjoyed all through school was Art. Even before I went to Chingford High, I loved drawing and painting. As well as doing it at Chase Lane Primary, Joan had all the stuff we needed for painting inside the hut in the park. On a rainy day at home, I'd spend hours copying Disney cartoon figures out of comics. I seem to remember Donald Duck was my specialty. As I got older, I began drawing cartoon figures that I'd made up myself. Even the artwork ended up coming back to soccer, though. Once I started playing for Ridgeway Rovers, instead of Mickey and Donald, I started drawing cartoons of games and the other people involved with the team: great goals, complete with Stuart Underwood in the background, his speech bubble describing what was going on in the rest of the picture.

Playing for the school team was the way into higher level soccer, of course, and I was able to represent my District with Waltham Forest and my County with Essex. I've been lucky to have such good coaching ever since those evenings over in the park with Dad. Don Wiltshire and Martin Heather were both great for me as a teenager, though they couldn't have been more different. Don, who managed the District side, was this solid, well-built man with a deep voice and a way about him that told you he knew exactly what he wanted for the team. When I first started playing for Waltham Forest, it felt like being selected to play for England.

People criticize schools soccer sometimes, saying it's all about getting the ball down the other end quickly, using kick and rush tactics, with the bigger kids always being the ones who get a game. All I can say is, it wasn't like that for me at school, at District or County level. It took me a little while to get into the side because I was so much smaller than most of the other boys my age. But once I had a chance, Don and Martin both used to encourage me, and the rest of the team, to play to our strengths.

Martin Heather was the Essex manager and the exact opposite to Don—or